READBACK

AI ATC FOR DCS

User Manual

How to run Readback ATC on your DCS World server, set it up the way your squadron flies, and talk to its controllers.

1. The controllers

Each controller is a station on SRS that listens on its frequency and answers your pilots by voice.

Station	What it does
Towers	One per airfield: radio checks, startup, taxi, takeoff, departure handoff, the overhead break and landing, go-arounds, emergencies, traffic alerts.
ATIS	A recorded weather and runway broadcast for each field, kept in step with its tower.
Command	The strike net: check-in, fence in/out, tasking, tankers, recoveries and diverts.
AWACS (GCI)	Picture, bogey dope, declare, snaplock, threat calls and vectors, from the air picture Tacview sees.
Marshal, Deckboss, Paddles	Carrier operations: the marshal stack and approach, the deck and catapults, and the LSO on the ball.
Tankers, JTAC	Air-to-air refuelling check-in and join-up, and close air support 9-lines, where your start files include them.

2. The dashboard

Open **Readback ATC** from the Start menu, or **http://localhost:7000**.

- **Theatre buttons** pick the map. **Start** runs every controller in it; **Stop** stops them all.
- **Cards** show each controller, its frequency, and whether it is running, with Start/Stop for each.
- **Tower status** shows each field's runway, weather and traffic.
- **Logs** shows what the controllers heard and said, live.
- Banners at the top show the trial days left, an available update, or that Setup is not finished.

3. Settings

Section	What you set
Squadron	Name and logo on every page.
Updates	Your version, what's new in the latest, and **Update now**.
Licence	Trial or licence status; paste a licence key here.
Voice services	**Windows voices** (free) or **OpenAI voices** (natural), and the OpenAI and ElevenLabs keys. Each key has a **Test** button.
Reports	Your own Claude API key, for written debriefs on the Reports page (optional).
Server connection	The SRS server, its External AWACS Mode password, and Tacview.
Frequencies	Each field's tower, ATIS and departure-handoff frequency. Changed values are marked; clear a box to go back to the default.
Roles	For every station: frequency, name, ElevenLabs voice, OpenAI voice, speed, and on/off. ▶ plays a sample of a voice. Moving Command or Marshal also moves the handoffs that point to it.

> Changes reach a controller when it restarts: use **Restart this theatre's roles** under Roles, or Stop and Start on the dashboard. Tell your pilots when you move a frequency.

Each tower card on the dashboard has a **Blue/Red** switch: a red field's tower talks to the red coalition on SRS and hands its departures to Red Command, for servers that run one.

4. Talking to Readback

- Tune the station's frequency (AM on UHF and VHF, FM below 88 MHz).
- Say **the station first, then your callsign**, then the request: *"Batumi Tower, Viper 1-1, request taxi."*
- Use a two-part callsign such as *Viper 1-1* or a modex such as *Raider 302*, and keep it the same all flight.
- Release the transmit key and wait for the answer. If it didn't hear you, ask *"say again"* or call again.

The calls below are the ones Readback is tested against. Similar wordings work too.

Tower

When	Say
Radio check	Batumi Tower, Viper 1-1, radio check.
Before engines	Batumi Tower, Viper 1-1, request startup.
Taxi	Batumi Tower, Viper 1-1, request taxi.
At the hold	Batumi Tower, Viper 1-1, holding short.
Takeoff	Batumi Tower, Viper 1-1, ready for takeoff.

After takeoff	Batumi Tower, Viper 1-1, airborne.
Leaving the area	Batumi Tower, Viper 1-1, seven DME.
Coming back	Batumi Tower, Viper 1-1, 10 mile initial.
Overhead break	Batumi Tower, Viper 1-1, break.
Straight in	Batumi Tower, Viper 1-1, request straight in.
Base / final	Batumi Tower, Viper 1-1, base, gear down. / ... on final.
Go-around	Batumi Tower, Viper 1-1, going around.
Off the runway	Batumi Tower, Viper 1-1, runway vacated.
Wind	Batumi Tower, Viper 1-1, wind check.
Emergency	Batumi Tower, Viper 1-1, mayday mayday mayday.

Command

When	Say
Check in	Command, Viper 1-1, checking in.
Fence in, with fuel	Command, Viper 1-1, fence in, state 6.2.
Ask for work	Command, Viper 1-1, request tasking.
Tanker	Command, Viper 1-1, request tanker.
Bullseye	Command, Viper 1-1, say bullseye.
Weapons / shots	Command, Viper 1-1, in hot. / ... pickle. / ... Fox 3.
Fuel	Command, Viper 1-1, Joker. / ... Bingo, RTB.
Going home	Command, Viper 1-1, fence out. / ... RTB.

AWACS (callsign as set, e.g. Darkstar)

When	Say
Check in	Darkstar, Viper 1-1, checking in.
The air picture	Darkstar, Viper 1-1, picture.
Nearest threat to you	Darkstar, Viper 1-1, bogey dope.
Identify a contact	Darkstar, Viper 1-1, declare bullseye 010 for 48 at 25000.
Contact on your nose	Darkstar, Viper 1-1, snaplock 125 for 10 at 8000.
RWR spike	Darkstar, Viper 1-1, spiked 080.
Steer	Darkstar, Viper 1-1, vector to tanker.
Kill	Darkstar, Viper 1-1, splash one.
Leaving	Darkstar, Viper 1-1, checking out.

Carrier

Station	Say
Deckboss	Deckboss, Viper 1-1, request taxi. / ... ready cat 2. / ... airborne. / ... pushing Marshal.
Marshal	Marshal, Viper 1-1, checking in. / ... marking moms, angels 12, state 6.5. / ... commencing. / ... platform. / ... clear seven miles.
Paddles	Paddles, Raider 302, Hornet ball, 5.5. / ... Clara, 5.0.

Tanker and JTAC (where your start files include them)

Station	Say
Tanker	Texaco 1-1, Viper 1-1, 15 mile initial for port observation, intent to refuel. / ... established port observation. / ... checking out.
JTAC	Hitman, Viper 1-1, checking in. / ... IP inbound. / ... in from the south. / ... off. / ... request BDA.

5. Frequencies

Towers use each field's DCS tower frequency; Settings > Frequencies lists them for your theatre. The standard start files put **Command on 282.000**, the **AWACS on 264.000** (or what you chose in Setup), **Marshal on 306.300** and **Deckboss on 128.600**. Give your pilots these on their kneeboard or preset card, and update them whenever you change one in Settings.

6. Reports: After Action Reports

The **Reports** page makes an After Action Report of a session: a summary page with the result, a relief map of every kill and the pilot, engagement and missile tables; a page per engagement with the fight's tracks and missiles and every shot (range, launch altitude and speed, kill or miss); the pilots' sorties, flight time and carrier grades; the Safety items (blue-on-blue, ground impacts, ejections); and the AAR itself - BLUF, plan, sustain / improve and recommendations with owners. Every number and map is worked out on this PC; Claude writes the words, with your own Claude API key (Settings > Reports; create one at console.anthropic.com, billed by Anthropic per report - usually a few cents).

1. Pick the session's records, each found on this PC or uploaded: the **mission file** (.miz: what was planned), the **Tacview recording** (.acmi or .zip.acmi: the tracks) and the **DCS server's dcs.log** (the shots, kills, takeoffs, landings and grades DCS scored). It must be the *server's* log (`Saved Games\DCS.dcs_serverrelease\Logs` on the server); a game client's dcs.log has none of them.
2. Leave **Include the radio logs** ticked to add what was said on Readback's frequencies.
3. Optionally say what to focus on, e.g. "Venom flight's carrier recovery".
4. Press **Preview**: the report's pages appear with everything but Claude's words, and you can read exactly what will be sent.
5. Press **Write the AAR**. Then **Download PDF**, **Print**, or post it: the **Discord post** box has the announcement ready to copy, with the PDF or a picture of the summary page to attach.

Reports are kept in the `reports` folder.

7. When something is wrong

- **No answer**: the controller must be running (dashboard), the pilot on its frequency, and the call must start with the station's name. The Logs page shows what it heard.
- **It heard something else**: speak after the transmit key is down, a little slower, station first. Check SRS isn't clipping your microphone.
- **No voice at all**: send the test call in Setup (step 5); it reports exactly what is missing.
- **Command or AWACS can't see aircraft**: check Tacview's real-time telemetry is on and its address is right in Settings.

See the Installation Guide for install problems, the trial, licences and updates.

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